

# Neobank Sprint

Your group runs a neobank for several sprints. You plan, build, get hit by an incident, release, and watch the regulator react. Most customers at the end wins — if you can still ship by then.

## The three rolls

| ROLL            | FORMULA                                                                                           | NOTE                              |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| <b>DEVELOP</b>  | $d20 + \text{Dev} \geq \text{sum of the targets you picked (+ legacy drag)}$                      | all or nothing                    |
| <b>MITIGATE</b> | $d20 + \text{Mit} \geq \text{the incident's target}$                                              | what you built earlier moves this |
| <b>RELEASE</b>  | $d20 + \text{Rel} - \text{bugs} - 2 \text{ per buggy feature} \geq \text{sum of release targets}$ | miss it → 25% of the reward       |

## The six phases of a sprint

| #  | PHASE                         | WHAT HAPPENS                                                         |
|----|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 01 | <b>Sprint Planning</b>        | Each group picks features up to its capacity, then commits.          |
| 02 | <b>Development</b>            | One d20 per group against the combined target. All or nothing.       |
| 03 | <b>Incident</b>               | One card. It hits every group, but not equally.                      |
| 04 | <b>Release</b>                | Built is not shipped. Bugs tax every release roll.                   |
| 05 | <b>Market Event</b>           | The world reacts to the portfolio you have actually built.           |
| 06 | <b>Retro &amp; Investment</b> | Two points, three for a sprint handled well. They do not carry over. |

## Two kinds of debt

|              | BUGS                              | AUDIT FINDINGS                        |
|--------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Earned by    | Pushing unfinished work through   | Failed incidents and regulatory cards |
| Taxes        | Every Release roll                | Every Mitigation roll                 |
| Hard wall    | 5 bugs → nothing ships at all     | 3 findings → one slot less capacity   |
| Paid down by | Automated Testing, or a slot (−2) | Compliance by Design, or a slot (−1)  |

## Legacy drag

**One platform card carries two product features.** Every product feature past that adds +1 to your combined Development target, up to +6. Platform cards earn few customers and pay a permanent modifier instead — capped at +4 in each of Dev, Rel and Mit. The bug counter models unfinished work; legacy drag models the architecture you never built.

## Investment points

Every retro pays **two**. From sprint 3 it pays a **third** if the sprint handled its incident — rolled against it and won, or built the card that removes it — or ended with no bugs. Only one extra point, however well both went. **Points do not carry over:** whatever is not spent at the retro is gone when the next sprint starts, so the three-point practices are only within reach in a sprint that earned the bonus.

## Paying down debt

A slot does not have to go on a feature. In planning you may spend one on remediation instead: **one slot clears two bugs, or one audit finding**. It takes effect at the start of Development, before the release roll — so at five bugs, one slot gets you shipping again in the same sprint. It costs you whatever that slot would have earned.

## The table

Six cards each sprint: three product, three platform. One of each rotates off the table at the end of the sprint, whether or not anyone took it — a card is therefore available for exactly three sprints. Capacity is 2 slots, 3 with Cross-Functional Team, 1 fewer while you hold three open findings. The two migration cards cost three slots on their own and stay off the table until the third slot can be bought. Taking no new work is a legal move.

## Product cards (15)

Customers now. Nothing permanent.

| CARD                    | KIND       | DEV | REL | USERS | COST | WHAT IT IS                                                          |
|-------------------------|------------|-----|-----|-------|------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Crypto Custody          | growth     | 15  | 14  | 30k   | 2    | High reward, high scrutiny. Ask the regulator first.                |
| Robo-Advisor            | growth     | 14  | 13  | 26k   | 2    | Suitability questionnaire, model portfolios, MiFID paperwork.       |
| SEPA Instant Payments   | core       | 13  | 12  | 22k   | 2    | Ten-second settlement, 24/7/365. No maintenance window.             |
| Mobile App Redesign     | growth     | 8   | 11  | 20k   | 1    | The thing customers actually judge you on.                          |
| FX & Multi-Currency     | growth     | 12  | 11  | 19k   | 2    | Interbank rates with a transparent markup.                          |
| Card Issuing            | core       | 11  | 10  | 18k   | 2    | Virtual and physical debit cards on a scheme BIN.                   |
| Merchant Payouts        | core       | 12  | 11  | 17k   | 2    | Same-day settlement for business customers.                         |
| Savings Pots            | growth     | 7   | 9   | 14k   | 1    | Sub-accounts with goals and round-ups.                              |
| Real-Time Notifications | growth     | 6   | 8   | 11k   | 1    | Push within a second of authorisation.                              |
| KYC Onboarding          | compliance | 9   | 7   | 10k   | 1    | Identity verification before the first euro moves.                  |
| PSD2 Open Banking API   | compliance | 10  | 9   | 9k    | 1    | Account information and payment initiation for third parties.       |
| Fraud Detection         | compliance | 12  | 8   | 8k    | 2    | Real-time scoring on the authorisation path.                        |
| Strong Customer Auth    | compliance | 9   | 8   | 6k    | 1    | Two factors, dynamic linking, PSD2 Article 97.                      |
| AML Monitoring          | compliance | 11  | 7   | 5k    | 1    | Transaction surveillance and suspicious-activity reports.           |
| Privacy & GDPR Controls | compliance | 8   | 6   | 4k    | 1    | Consent, retention, erasure. Pays nothing until it pays everything. |

## Agile practices (12)

Bought with Investment Points at the retro. Permanent, and they compound.

| PRACTICE              | COST | SESSION | EFFECT                                                       |
|-----------------------|------|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pair Programming      | 2 IP | 01      | +2 on every Development roll.                                |
| Automated Testing     | 2 IP | 06      | Clears 1 bug each retro. +3 against dependency incidents.    |
| CI/CD Pipeline        | 2 IP | 06      | +3 on every Release roll.                                    |
| Definition of Done    | 3 IP | 06      | Pushed-through features no longer create bugs.               |
| Feature Flags         | 2 IP | 06      | Shelved features still earn 20% of their reward.             |
| Modular Architecture  | 2 IP | 04      | Picking 2+ features lowers the combined Dev target by 3.     |
| Observability & SRE   | 2 IP | 04      | +2 on Mitigation. Outages no longer hit you harder.          |
| Agentic Coding        | 3 IP | 05      | +3 on Development — but pushing through costs 2 bugs, not 1. |
| Blameless Postmortems | 1 IP | 06      | +3 on Mitigation rolls.                                      |
| Retro Culture         | 3 IP | 00      | +1 on every roll you make.                                   |
| Cross-Functional Team | 3 IP | 01      | One more feature slot per sprint.                            |
| Compliance by Design  | 3 IP | 10      | Clears 1 audit finding each retro.                           |

## Platform cards (24)

Few customers, permanent leverage. The session number is the lecture the card comes from.

| CARD                   | S  | DEV | REL | USERS | COST | PERMANENT     | WHAT IT IS                                                                                 |
|------------------------|----|-----|-----|-------|------|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Core Ledger            | 01 | 12  | 8   | 6k    | 2    | —             | Double-entry bookkeeping. Every balance in the bank derives from it.                       |
| Documentation Wiki     | 01 | 6   | 4   | 2k    | 1    | Dev +1        | Decisions written down where the next person will look for them.                           |
| Database Sharding      | 02 | 13  | 7   | 5k    | 2    | Mit +1        | Partition the ledger by customer range. Writes stop fighting each other.                   |
| Data Pipeline          | 02 | 12  | 7   | 6k    | 2    | Rel +1        | Streaming ingestion, not a nightly batch and a prayer. Everything downstream gets fresher. |
| Data Warehouse         | 02 | 10  | 5   | 3k    | 2    | Mit +1        | Dull, cheap, and the only place the regulator's numbers reconcile.                         |
| Caching Layer          | 02 | 9   | 6   | 5k    | 1    | Rel +1        | Balance reads served from memory instead of hammering the core.                            |
| Performance Profiling  | 02 | 9   | 6   | 4k    | 1    | Rel +1        | Find the query that costs you the p99 instead of guessing at it.                           |
| Load Balancer          | 02 | 8   | 5   | 4k    | 1    | Mit +1        | Spread the traffic and drain a node without an outage.                                     |
| CDN Integration        | 02 | 7   | 5   | 6k    | 1    | Rel +1        | Static assets close to the customer. The app stops feeling slow abroad.                    |
| Core Banking Migration | 04 | 16  | 9   | 12k   | 3    | Dev +1 Rel +1 | Off the legacy mainframe. The one everybody postpones.                                     |
| Microservice Migration | 04 | 14  | 8   | 7k    | 3    | Rel +2        | Break the monolith so two teams stop queueing behind one deploy.                           |
| Disaster Recovery      | 04 | 12  | 6   | 2k    | 2    | Mit +1        | Second region, tested failover, documented RTO.                                            |
| API Gateway            | 04 | 11  | 7   | 5k    | 2    | Rel +1        | One edge for auth, routing and versioning instead of twelve.                               |
| Observability Stack    | 04 | 10  | 5   | 3k    | 1    | Mit +2        | Traces, metrics, structured logs. Nobody asks for it.                                      |
| Containerization       | 04 | 10  | 6   | 3k    | 2    | Dev +1 Rel +1 | The same image in dev, staging and production. No more works-on-my-machine.                |
| Backup & Recovery      | 04 | 9   | 5   | 2k    | 1    | Mit +1        | Point-in-time restore that somebody has actually tested this year.                         |
| Service Monitoring     | 04 | 8   | 5   | 3k    | 1    | Mit +1        | Health checks and alerting, so the customer is not your monitoring.                        |
| Incident Runbooks      | 04 | 7   | 4   | 2k    | 1    | Mit +2        | Written, rehearsed, and findable at three in the morning.                                  |
| Rate Limiting          | 04 | 7   | 5   | 3k    | 1    | Mit +1        | Per-client quotas on the public API. The cheapest abuse defence there is.                  |
| Test Automation Suite  | 06 | 10  | 6   | 3k    | 2    | Dev +1 Rel +1 | A suite that runs on every commit and actually gets read when it fails.                    |
| A/B Testing System     | 06 | 10  | 8   | 9k    | 2    | Rel +1        | Ship to five percent first and find out before everyone sees it.                           |
| Code Quality Gates     | 06 | 9   | 5   | 2k    | 1    | Dev +2        | Coverage, linting and review rules enforced by the pipeline, not by asking nicely.         |
| Error Tracking         | 06 | 8   | 5   | 3k    | 1    | Mit +1        | Exceptions aggregated and attributed instead of scrolling a log.                           |
| Security Audit Log     | 10 | 9   | 5   | 3k    | 1    | Mit +1        | Tamper-evident record of who touched which account. The supervisor will ask.               |

## Incidents (12)

One card per sprint. It hits every group, but not equally.

| INCIDENT                      | TARGET | WHAT MOVES THE ROLL                                         | IF YOU FAIL                           |
|-------------------------------|--------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Payday Peak Outage            | 12     | Observability avoids -3; Caching or Sharding +3             | -10% customers, +1 bug                |
| Data Breach                   | 14     | Privacy & GDPR +2; Security Audit Log +2                    | -26% (-14% with Privacy), +2 findings |
| Lead Engineer Resigns         | —      | Pair Programming or Documentation Wiki removes it           | -3 on this sprint's Dev roll          |
| BaFin Spot Audit              | 13     | AML Monitoring +3; Security Audit Log +2                    | +2 audit findings                     |
| Card Scheme Mandate           | 11     | CI/CD Pipeline +3                                           | releases blocked this sprint          |
| Fraud Ring                    | 12     | Fraud Detection removes it; Rate Limiting +3                | -13%, +1 finding                      |
| Cloud Region Failure          | 13     | Disaster Recovery removes it; Backup +3, Load Balancer +1   | -16% customers                        |
| Critical Dependency CVE       | 12     | Automated Testing or Test Suite +3; Gates +1; Containers +1 | +2 bugs                               |
| Instant Payment SLA Breach    | 12     | only hits you if you shipped SEPA Instant                   | -12%, +1 finding                      |
| Blame Storm                   | —      | Blameless Postmortems removes it                            | -1 Investment Point                   |
| Regulatory Reporting Deadline | 11     | Data Warehouse removes it; Data Pipeline +3                 | +1 finding, -5%                       |
| Customer Phishing Wave        | 12     | Strong Customer Auth +4; Rate Limiting +2                   | -9% customers                         |

## Market events (13)

One card per sprint, resolved against what each group has actually built. Gains are fixed amounts; losses are a share of the customers you already have, so they grow with you.

| EVENT                        | PAYS                                               | COSTS                           |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| DORA Comes Into Force        | Disaster Recovery → +12k                           | otherwise -10%, +1 finding      |
| GDPR Enforcement Wave        | Privacy & GDPR → +8k                               | otherwise -16%                  |
| Instant Payments Regulation  | SEPA Instant → +15k                                | otherwise -9%                   |
| Funding Winter               | —                                                  | leader -14%, everyone else -7%  |
| App Store Feature Spot       | the leader → +13k                                  | —                               |
| MiCA Licensing Round         | Crypto Custody → +18k                              | —                               |
| Central Bank Raises Rates    | Savings Pots → +14k                                | otherwise -5%                   |
| Open Banking Breakthrough    | PSD2 API → +11k                                    | —                               |
| Reviewer Tests Every Neobank | fewest bugs → +12k                                 | otherwise -4% per bug           |
| Incumbent Price War          | Mobile App → only -2%                              | otherwise -12%                  |
| Consumer Trust Index         | no findings → +9k                                  | 1-2 → -5%, three or more → -15% |
| Latency Benchmark Published  | two of CDN / Caching / Profiling → +12k, one → +3k | none → -10%                     |
| Engineering Brand            | two of Wiki / Gates / Test Suite → +2k and +1 IP   | —                               |

## Sprint tracker

Fill this in as you go. Your console keeps the real numbers — this is for the debrief, so you can point at the sprint where it turned.

| SPRINT | PICKED | DEV ROLL | INCIDENT | RELEASED | CUSTOMERS | BUGS | FINDINGS | BOUGHT |
|--------|--------|----------|----------|----------|-----------|------|----------|--------|
| 1      |        |          |          |          |           |      |          |        |
| 2      |        |          |          |          |           |      |          |        |
| 3      |        |          |          |          |           |      |          |        |
| 4      |        |          |          |          |           |      |          |        |
| 5      |        |          |          |          |           |      |          |        |
| 6      |        |          |          |          |           |      |          |        |
| 7      |        |          |          |          |           |      |          |        |
| 8      |        |          |          |          |           |      |          |        |

Adapted from the CatTube sprint game, itself inspired by the “Agile 101” board game by Emma Hopkinson-Spark (101 Ways).